of the night, we had observed close to 200 such passes. We waited on tenterhooks for the dawn to reveal the situation. When the sun rose, we scanned the area on the other side and there was nothing, absolutely nothing to be seen. We had fully expected a jumble of vehicles hidden in the jungle on the other side—where else could the vehicles have been dispersed and camouflaged? We scanned each thicket and clump of trees repeatedly but to no avail. It was not our imagination either, so many personnel had seen the same thing. This remained a mystery till the end; perhaps it was just a tractor going round and round, but it demonstrated that we were alert and had not let our guard down.

Being in the middle of nowhere, the location had a variety of wildlife. Snakes, particularly vipers, were quite common, as were hyenas howling at night. Wild boars were common in the Forward Zone, especially on the Pakistani side. While patrolling or laying an ambush at night, more than the enemy, we had to be alert to guard against snake bites and getting mauled by these animals. On one occasion, when there were two such bite cases on two consecutive nights, the CO had to give an explanation, to which he could only reply that unfortunately, the hyenas were not subject to the Army Act and hence, not listening to his orders. Such is life, having to give explanations for doing your job.

This was also the time when the Siachen issue was brewing. It was all shrouded in secrecy, but all units were asked for officer volunteers for high-risk missions (HRM). There were plenty of volunteers, but then came another directive that the volunteers must be unmarried, which underscored how risky the missions were going to be. On account of this, many of us became ineligible and from the names forwarded to the Brigade, Narendra Parmar was selected. On the day he was to

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